



certain actions
are right or
wrong

A solid green circle with a subtle drop shadow, centered on a white background. Inside the circle, the text "certain people or lives are better or worse than others" is written in a white, sans-serif font, arranged in five lines.

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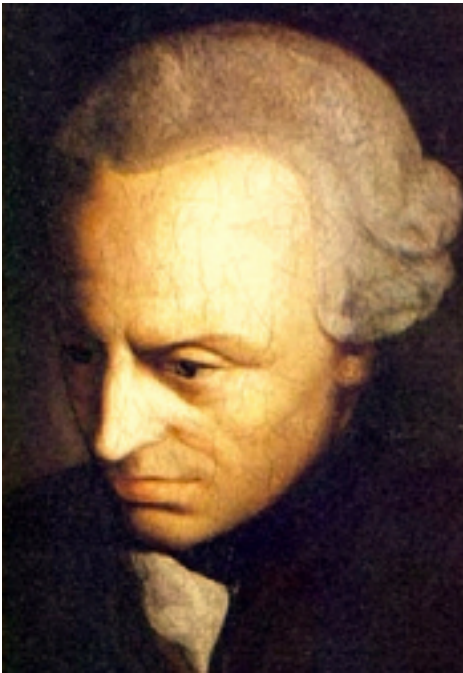
The consequentialist takes the goodness or badness of situations as fundamental, and tries to explain the others in terms of these. What would it look like if we took one of the other categories as most fundamental?

A **deontological** approach to what we ought to do takes facts about the rightness and wrongness of actions as basic, and does not try to explain the rightness or wrongness of actions in terms of the goodness or badness of the action's outcomes.

There are lots of different deontological theories. I'm going to briefly introduce you to one, which is based on the idea that people have certain basic **rights**. On this view, wrong actions are actions which violate someone's rights.

But what are rights, and which actions violate them?

One answer to this question was given by the 18th century German philosopher Immanuel Kant.



Kant thought that all human beings have dignity, and that this means that we all have the right not to be used as a way to satisfy the desires of others.

The second is that there are plenty of cases where there seems to be a moral obligation to do or not do something, even though, either way, no one is treating anyone else as a mere means. Let's consider three examples of this.

The second are cases of simple disregard. Suppose that I drive very quickly out of my neighborhood and run over a child. It does not seem that I used the child as a means to an end; but this was surely wrong.

The first are cases which involve no actions toward other human beings. Consider, for example, animal cruelty or environmental destruction. These actions involve treating no one as a mere means, but seem clearly wrong.

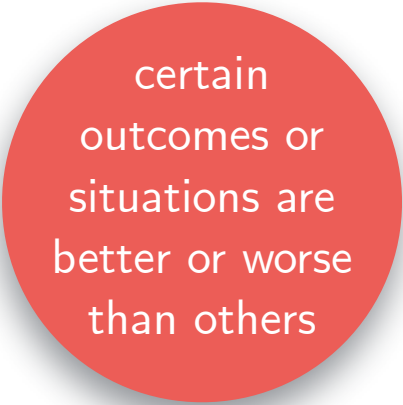
The third are cases in which there is a huge gap in the goodness of the outcome. Consider a version of the basic trolley case in which there are 1000 people on the track in front of one. Surely one is morally required to turn the trolley to kill the one. But you can let the trolley continue on its path without using anyone as a means to an end.

There is a troubling variant on this last kind of case. If we make the consequences bad enough, it can seem very plausible that some cases of using someone as a means to an end are morally permissible, and even required.

Take the case of the fat man. Suppose that by pushing him you can prevent the detonation of a hydrogen bomb which would kill millions. It seems plausible that in this case you are not just permitted, but required, to push him. But how can we get this result without opting for some form of consequentialism?



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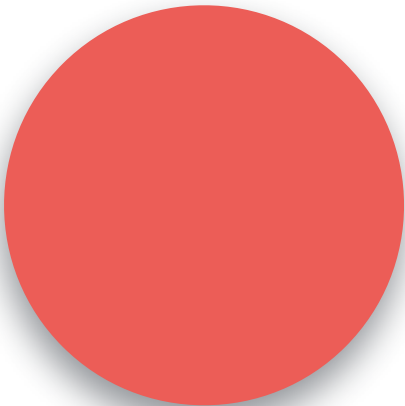
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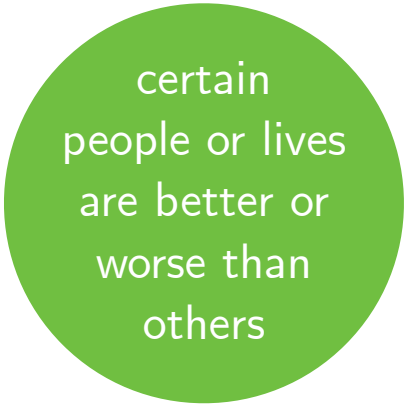
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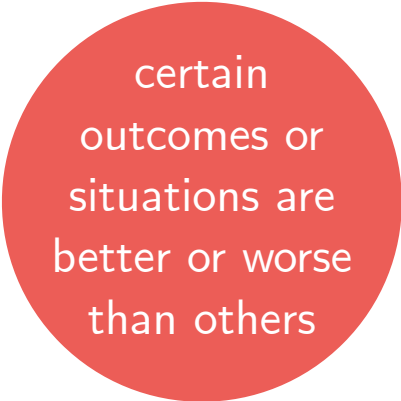


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